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Gender differences in travel behaviour and willingness to adopt sustainable behaviour

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ABSTRACT

This paper presents pioneering research on gender differences in travel behaviour in southeastern Europe. The study analyses the socio-economic and main travel characteristics (particularly parking) of men and women. Additionally, it examines the influence of parking demand management measures on their behaviour, in terms of the willingness of men and women to reduce car use and to adopt more sustainable behaviour. The results reveal significant differences between genders in most of the characteristics examined. Moreover, it is shown that women are less car dependent and more sensitive to parking pricing and, therefore, more willing to replace a car journey with public transport. These findings suggest that gender should be an essential parameter when user behaviour is examined and modelled. Furthermore, the results indicate that gender differences must be considered when transport policy is created to affect the behaviour of men and women equally. The achievement of social equality is one of the primary objectives of sustainable development.

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Gender; travel behaviour; parking demand management; parking price sensitivity; sustainability

1. Introduction

The modern concept of transport management implies the development of sustainable transport. This transport should ensure that environmental, social, and economic considerations are included in decisions concerning transport activity (VTPI 2011). Given these three aspects of sustainability, sustainable transport's objectives are multidimensional and often conflicting, and thus are highly difficult to achieve. Maximising the realisation of certain objectives can lead to the minimisation of others; therefore, a compromise is difficult to avoid.

Sustainable transport typically limits car usage while relying on non-motorised transport modes (pedestrian and bicycle) and public transport. Transport demand management (in terms of modal shift and temporal and spatial redistribution) is emphasised, and it requires changes in travel behaviour. This property means that the success of transport demand management measures depends on its acceptance by users.

These measures are often criticised for not being fair and equal to all social classes and groups. For example, transport charges are often labelled as unequal because they more

affect people with lower incomes. To date, however, almost no attention has been paid to whether these measures lead to gender inequality, i.e. that is, whether they affect both men and women equally.

Lately, there has been extensive criticism due to gender-blind transport research and planning. Transport policies are considered to be defined without examination of specific women's needs, and, therefore, they are tailored to fit men's needs. Currently, many studies and papers are proving that gender is one of the socio-economic characteristics with the greatest impact on travel behaviour (Curtis and Perkins 2006). Some research also shows that, on average, women are more willing to adopt sustainable behaviour, explaining this with the evidence that women are more concerned with environmental issues than men (Polk 2004). However, this issue, although critical, is still considered to be understudied especially in more traditional societies.

This paper uses detailed parking survey data to examine gender variations in travel and particularly parking behaviour. The study also examines the influence of parking demand management measures on gender, above all in terms of willingness to reduce car use/parking.

The reason that this research is based on parking is that parking measures (such as parking charges and time limitation) require changes in user behaviour. In addition, these measures are often implemented and generally accepted (both by authorities and public) in central areas of cities worldwide. Parking behaviour greatly depicts the willingness of user (and of gender) to contribute to transport system sustainability.

This paper is based on survey findings from Belgrade, Serbia, which complement the knowledge base on gender differences in travel behaviour in developing countries.

The paper is structured as follows: the overview of literature examining the causes of gender differences in travel behaviour is given in Section 2. The needs and requirements of both men and women are shown, as well. In Section 3, we give a brief overview on the situation in Serbia and on the state of transport (and primarily parking) in Belgrade. Section 4 describes the methodology for gathering data used in the analysis of gender differences in parking behaviour. The results obtained by such methods as descriptive statistics and *t*-test are presented in Section 5. In Section 6, we provide concluding remarks and propose guidelines for further research.

2. Literature overview

Although neglected for many years, gender differences in travel behaviour have been drawing the attention of the professional and scientific public in the last decades. It is believed that these differences exist due to several reasons (Babcock and Laschever 2003; Scheiner 2014).

First of all, women earn less money than men (there even appears to be differences in pay between men and women doing exactly the same job). The European Commission reported in 2008 that in European Union (EU) countries women earn on average 17.5% less than men (during their lifetimes), which later leads to differences in pension between genders. Although the Commission has taken many actions to tackle this gap (such as support of equal pay initiatives at the workplace, improvement of pay transparency, and encouragement of women and men to enter non-traditional professions), it seems that progress in reducing the gender pay gap has been slow (<http://europa.eu/>

rapid/press-release_IP-11-255_en.htm?locale=en). This slow pace is confirmed by the results of the 2013 Eurobarometer survey in which 82% of respondents perceive the problem of differences in pay to be urgent to address, while 61% consider that the decisions on the promotion of gender equality at the EU level are of great importance. A similar situation is in the United States where working full-time women made approximately 77 cents for every dollar earned by men in 2011. Although the differences have decreased since 1951, when women earned only 64 cents, they are still very relevant (<http://www.pay-equity.org/info-time.html>). Weaker economic power as well as the fact that women rarely work in wealthy firms having their own cars (Law 1999) are reasons why women use cars less and are more sensitive to (transport) charges.

The reason why women are paid less has been considered to be due to their disproportionate commitment to household and family responsibilities. It is often argued that women are at a disadvantage in career advancement because they do not have the same priorities. It is believed that many women choose less paid jobs that will allow them more frequent absences and will require less effort (Blau and Ferber 1990). Several studies even show that women seek a job close to their residence to facilitate household-related travel (Sermons and Koppelman 2001). Taylor and Mauch (2000) show that single men and single women have quite similar travel behaviour because single men have full responsibility for their own household duties. However, the critical events in the life course do not affect men and women equally: marriage and particularly birth of children lead to differences in behaviour because women take most of the responsibility on themselves (Scheiner 2014). Women do far more household-related travel than men on average.

The reason for the sexual division of household labour has been described as the long-standing patriarchal power relations that may operate over and above economic inequalities (Scheiner 2014). Women themselves are sometimes blamed for this inequality because they are not sufficiently committed to gender equality and do not ask for greater engagement of men (Scheiner 2014).

Gender differences in travel behaviour are empirically confirmed. It is interesting to note that there is no inconsistency among research results, which reveals that generally speaking, men's/women's travel patterns are similar worldwide.

Results show that men use the car more than women (Polk 2003, 2004; Elias, Newmark, and Shiftan 2008), while women use more public transport and walk (Polk 2003; Elias, Newmark, and Shiftan 2008).

Furthermore, women make fewer trips per day and tend to have shorter average trip lengths (Polk 2003; Elias, Newmark, and Shiftan 2008). Men spend more time for travel (Elias, Newmark, and Shiftan 2008) (both when they commute [Sermons and Koppelman 2001] and for other purposes [Taylor and Mauch 2000]) and also spend more time at activities than women (Elias, Newmark, and Shiftan 2008). Trip purposes also significantly differ: men make more business and work-related trips than women, while women make more trips for household purposes such as childcare and (grocery) shopping (Taylor and Mauch 2000).

Finally, apart from different trip characteristics, there are gender differences in the response to and acceptance of transport demand management measures. Polk (2003, 2004), setting up and using results from Sweden, confirmed the hypothesis that women are more aware and supportive of sustainable behaviour: they are more environmentally

concerned and express more criticism of automobility and, therefore, express more willingness to reduce car usage than men. Therefore, she concludes that researchers must consider gender as a factor in attitudinal research regarding car use.

Most of these studies come from developed Western countries. Conversely, it can be noted that this issue has not yet been recognised in underdeveloped and developing countries, and several authors emphasise that there is a lack of literature in this part of the world. Exceptions are studies from Israel (Elias, Newmark, and Shiftan 2008), India (Srinivasan 2006), Brazil, and Kenya (Turner and Fouracre 1995). The studies are usually concentrated on an examination of the modal split by gender, demonstrating a disproportionate share of women travelling by public transport and walking.

3. Situation in Belgrade, Serbia

As already noted, this paper uses data gathered in Belgrade, Serbia. Serbia is considered to be a developing country with a basically traditional society and noticeable differences between genders. On the other hand, Serbia is trying to follow the trends of developed countries (especially the EU member states), as it is in accession negotiations with the EU. Serbian legislation promotes the highest international standards. The 2009 Gender Equality Law states that gender equality means equal participation of women and men in all spheres of the public and private sectors, in accordance with the generally accepted rules of international law. Consequently, the inclusion of women in appropriate institutions and positions of social and political importance has been favoured in recent years (e.g. women should constitute at least 30% of the total number of members of Parliament). The updated 2013 Labour Law stipulates that female employees are entitled to leave after childbirth for three months and childcare for 365 days while male employees have the right to leave for child care.

However, as in the EU and in the United States, women in Serbia are paid less. The Republic Statistical Office of Serbia published in 2010 the average salary of employees in legal entities according to gender; depending on the level of education, women's salaries were between 74% and 88% of men's salaries.

In Belgrade, the Serbian capital, there are approximately 1.5 million inhabitants who make approximately 3 million trips per day. Most of the trips are undertaken by public transport (52%), whereas the share of cars in daily trips is 22%. Although the modal split can be considered to be exceptional, traffic problems in Belgrade are evident. The reason for this is a very limited transport supply (approximately 67% of the primary street network has one lane per direction) along with out-dated traffic management that does not match real-time traffic demand (Jović and Djorić 2009).

The parking problem in Belgrade is traditionally most pronounced in its central area due to its great discrepancies between parking demand and supply. In the central area, there are approximately 14,000 public parking spaces, most of which are located on streets (83%), while the rest are in parking garages (13%) and off-street car parks (4%).

The parking problem is somewhat mitigated by the introduction of restrictive parking regimes on-street (parking charge and time limitation) in 2003. At that time, the central area was divided into three parking zones: in zone I (the Red zone) parking is time limited to one hour and costs 56 RSD (€ 0.48); in zone II (the Yellow zone) time limitation is two hours and parking costs 38 RSD (€ 0.33) per hour; while in zone III (the Green zone)

visitors can park for no longer than three hours, for which they pay 31 RSD (€ 0.28) per hour. The regime applies every weekday from 7 am to 9 pm and on Saturdays from 7 am to 2 pm. Residents have the opportunity to purchase parking permits at a price of 457 RSD (€ 3.94) per month, which does not guarantee a vacant parking space but allows parking without time limitation. The same rights (under specific conditions) apply to businesses with offices in this area, but prices are higher: depending on the zone, prices are 9130 RSD (€ 78.71), 6176 RSD (€ 53.24), or 4160 RSD (€ 35.86) per month, respectively. Although this parking regime significantly mitigated parking problems (Milosavljević, Maletić, and Simićević 2007), they are still obvious. In almost the entire period of the regime validity, on-street parking spaces are completely occupied and illegal parking occurs, making it difficult to find a vacant parking space.

In the public parking garages and off-street car parks, parking is charged non-stop. The parking price varies from facility to facility and is two to three times higher than the on-street parking price. Unlike on-street parking, parking garages and off-street car parks are never completely occupied, and a vacant parking space can be found anytime.

4. Methodology of survey

To the best of our knowledge, this study is a pioneering work on gender differences in travel behaviour in this part of Europe and is certainly the first of our research on this topic. Therefore, our goal was to become more familiar with the topic and to set guidelines for further work.

In view of the paper's aim, we decided to use data previously gathered for other purposes. Although the data were originally collected for different reasons, they include the main parameters necessary to meet the tasks set out in this paper. The existing data are sufficient to provide insight into the differences in travel behaviour between men and women, as well as to show us the direction in which further work and research should go.

The data were collected using face-to-face interviews with drivers who had just parked or who were leaving a parking space. The survey was conducted by students of the University of Belgrade's Faculty of Transport and Traffic Engineering. The survey was undertaken at eight on-street sections located within the Red zone, which represents the inner central area. The following characteristics were gathered:

- (1) Socio-economic characteristics of the driver: gender, income, and car dependency. In practice, income was not surveyed directly because previous studies have shown that respondents often refuse to answer or give an incorrect answer to this question (Shiftan and Burd-Eden 2001). Therefore, instead of income, two proxies were surveyed: engine size and age of the car (Simićević, Milosavljević, and Maletić 2012). Car dependency was determined using the question 'Do you use a car for every trip in the city?'
- (2) Parking/trip characteristics: trip origin and destination, car occupancy, user category (visitor or parking permit holder), whether employer pays for the parking, parking purpose and frequency, rank of parking quality parameters, and parking search time. Apart from parking search time, driver behaviour when cruising for parking was also investigated. In this regard, based on our previous work, two main 'parking search strategies' for local conditions were identified: the user first arrives

at the destination and subsequently begins to look for parking, or the user searches in advance while approaching the destination (Simićević and Vukanović 2013).

- (3) Visitor sensitivity to parking charge, which was determined using the question ‘What would you do if parking price (both on- and off-street) in the Red zone increased to 100 RSD per hour?’ However, it may seem that this hypothetical price is set too high (almost 80% higher than the existing one) and, as Hensher and King (2001) note, such a situation is difficult to conceive, and the stated response would, therefore, be questionable. However, we do not consider this to be a problem here because off-street parking prices amount up to 100 RSD (€ 0.86) per hour, so visitors already have an opinion about it.

The survey was carried out during five weekdays in November and December 2011 in the period between 7 am and 9 pm. This period was chosen as a period of the on-street parking regime validity.

5. Results

A total of 232 drivers were interviewed, of which 199 were men and 33 were women. As we believe that the interviewers approached both men and women equally to ask for the interview, and that both men and women were equally willing to participate in the survey, we can say that 85.8% of on-street users in the inner central area were men and only 14.2% were women. Regarding user category, the greatest share of women (20.3%) is in the category ‘resident permit holder’ (who pays the lowest price) and the lowest share (11.6%) is in the category ‘visitor’. When comparing the share of female parkers in the inner central area with the share of female drivers in the total number of car trips in the entire city of Belgrade (18.2%, SmartPlan 2008), it can be concluded that restrictive parking measures in the central area have affected more women than men.

A comparison of socio-economic and trip characteristics of men and women who park within the inner central area of Belgrade is given in Table 1.

The average engine size of a car driven by men is higher than the average engine size of a car driven by women (1688 cm³ vs. 1513 cm³), which can be partly explained by men’s

Table 1. Comparison of socio-economic characteristics and travel behaviour by gender.

Characteristics	Men		Women		Comparison	
	Mean	SD	Mean	SD	t(df)	Significance*
Socio-economic characteristics of drivers						
Engine size (cm ³)	1688	428	1513	309	$t(222) = 2.152$	0.032
Age of the car (years)	8.1	6.1	9.4	6.2	$t(147) = -0.849$	0.397
Car dependency (%)	76	43	52	51	$t(40) = 2.593$	0.013
Parking/trip characteristics						
Trip length (km)	10.3	18.1	6.7	12.5	$t(230) = 1.106$	0.270
Walking distance (m)	190	176	154	121	$t(225) = 1.106$	0.270
Parking search time (minute)	3.4	4.6	3.6	4.6	$t(225) = -0.221$	0.825
Employer pays for parking (%)	29	45	10	30	$t(55) = 3.026$	0.004
Car occupancy	1.34	0.56	1.34	0.72	$t(212) = -0.083$	0.934
Frequency: every day (%)	64	48	55	51	$t(228) = 1.091$	0.276

*Two-tailed *t*-test for equality of means.

Note: On the basis of Levene’s test, it was determined that variances are roughly equal for each characteristic, except for ‘car dependency’ and ‘employer pays for parking’ where variances are different.

tendency to drive bigger and more powerful cars. Cars driven by men are on average 8.1 years old, while the cars driven by women are 1.3 years older. These characteristics are taken for proxies of income, confirming the economic superiority of men. This is not surprising since it can be expected that the economic superiority of men is greater, but that it is often mitigated in families by resource-pooling between spouses (Law 1999). Additionally, parking costs for men are more often covered by employers than for women (28.8% and 9.7%, respectively) – which supports Law's (1999) assumption that men more often work in financially stronger companies that own cars.

There are no differences in occupancy of cars driven by men and women.

The average trip length of men is 10.6 km and for women it is 6.9 km. This finding of men's greater trip length is consistent with results from the literature (Section 2). One of the reasons may be the choice of residence location, where an important criterion is to be accessible for women because they do most of the household and family chores (Sermons and Koppelman 2001).

There is no significant difference in walking distance between genders: from parking space to final destination men walk 190 m and women 154 m. This suggests that walking distance depends primarily on the location where drivers manage to find a vacant parking space and not on drivers' willingness to walk because, as will be shown later, finding a vacant parking space is more important to drivers (of both genders) than walking distance. It is interesting to note that both genders spend almost the same time searching for a parking space (men need 3.4 minutes and women 3.6 minutes on average). However, while searching, men and women do not apply the same parking search strategy. Among men, 55.1% opt to arrive at the destination first and then begin to look for a parking space. On the other hand, the majority of women (66.7%), out of fear that a vacant parking space is difficult to find, search in advance while approaching the destination. Given their search strategy, it is expected that men would locate a parking space faster (Simićević and Vukanović 2013) and walk less. The reason why this is not the case is the parking occupancy at the moment of search: 42.5% of men come into the zone and search for parking during the period of increased area attractiveness and its maximum parking occupancy (between 10 am and 3 pm), while only 16.1% of women arrive during this period. The time of arrival can be associated with trip purpose.

When analysing trip purpose (Table 2), residents were not taken into consideration because many of them do not leave their parking space during the day such that their share cannot be determined by this type of survey. It has been shown that about 40% of residents in the Red zone do not leave their parking space during the day (Milosavljević et al. 2007). The results show that men park more often for purposes of 'work' and 'business' than women (52.8% vs. 35.0%). It can be expected that the share of purpose of 'work' would be higher if parking was not time limited to one hour, and this

Table 2. Users' distribution by gender and parking purpose.

Purpose	Male (%)	Female (%)
Shopping	7.5	5.0
Work	17.4	15.0
Leisure	11.2	25.0
Business	35.4	20.0
Private business	28.6	35.0

purpose typically requires long-term parking. The reason for the existence of this purpose in this zone is the parking permit for businesses. Additionally, due to the abuse of the system, persons not living within the zone can hold residential parking permits. Finally, because Serbia is a developing country and undergoing rapid transformation, the purpose of 'work' has changed its character such that, to a certain extent, it is performed within the scope resulting in a shorter duration than the one expected for this purpose (Simićević et al. 2012). On the other hand, women park for the purposes of 'work' and 'business' in 35.0% of cases. The primary reason for their parking in the zone is 'private business' (which also includes childcare), which again can be linked to a woman's role in the household.

Men are somewhat more frequent users of on-street parking than women: 64.5% of men interviewed park every day vs. 54.5% of women interviewed. More frequent men's trips and parking in the central area were expected with regard to their primary purpose ('work' and 'business' vs. 'private business'). More frequent zone visits and thus better knowledge of local conditions may be one of the reasons why men (unlike women) prefer to look for a parking space after reaching the destination, and not in advance.

Out of parking quality parameters, the following were presented to respondents: to find a vacant parking space, to walk less from the parking space to the destination, and to pay less for parking and vehicle security. Men and women ranked these parameters in the same way (Figure 1). The absence of gender differences in attitudes towards parking quality can mean that users with different attitudes gave up parking in the zone when the parking regime was introduced. The most important to users is to find a parking space, which testifies to the high parking occupancy (and in fact to low parking service quality). The least important to users is that parking is not expensive.

When analysing the gender differences in sustainable behaviour and in responses to parking demand management measures, it should first be mentioned once again that men are far more numerous users of central area on-street parking. Furthermore, the survey showed that a greater percentage of men use cars for all trips (75.8% vs. 51.5%). This parameter depicts user car dependency and can significantly influence user travel behaviour and his/her response to restrictive measures. Simićević, Vukanović, and

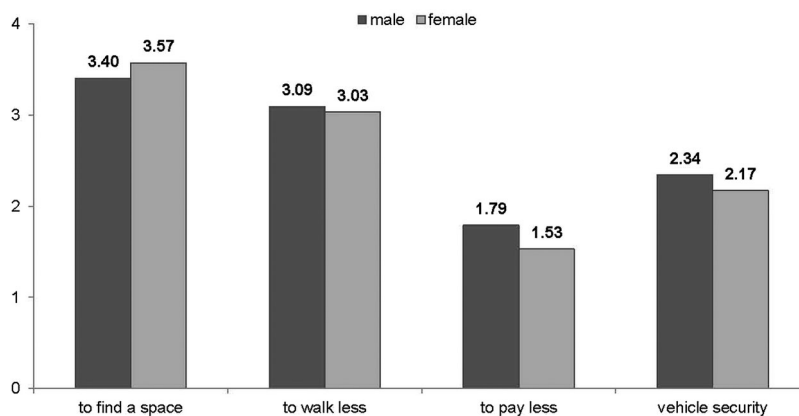


Figure 1. Grades of parking quality parameter by gender.

Milosavljević (2013) showed that people who use the car for all trips in the city are less sensitive to parking management measures (parking charge and time limitation) because it is more difficult for them to give up the comfort of the car.

Differences in price sensitivity were also examined using the user response to the hypothetical parking price increase to 100 RSD (€ 0.86) per hour. Based on the received responses, price elasticity was calculated, which represents the percentage change in parking demand caused by a 1% change in its price. We used linear arc elasticity because it is commonly used for prediction of road users' behaviour (Transit Cooperative Research Program 2005):

$$\eta = \frac{(\Delta Q / ((Q_1 + Q_2) / 2))}{(\Delta P / ((P_1 + P_2) / 2))}, \quad (1)$$

where η is the elasticity coefficient, P_1 the first parking price, P_2 the second (hypothetical) parking price, Q_1 the parking demand at price P_1 , and Q_2 the (predicted) parking demand at price P_2 .

The following elasticity coefficients were obtained: -0.29 for men and -0.44 for women, which confirmed the higher sensitivity of women. It is interesting to analyse alternatives that men and women would choose if they gave up parking in the area because of its price. Most men (66.7%) stated that they would drive to the edge of the area, park there and continue on foot or by public transport. This finding confirms their greater car dependency. Conversely, women are more willing to shift mode: 50.0% of women would move to public transport.

At first glance, it may seem that results related to price sensitivity contradict results of the parking quality parameter rank, where both men and women put the parameter 'to pay less' in last place and women gave it even less importance. Nevertheless, we should not forget that by ranking quality parameters we cannot determine the price sensitivity but only the importance of price in relation to the other parameters.

6. Conclusions

This, to the best of our knowledge, is the first paper in the region of Southeast Europe to deal with gender and travel behaviour. The results presented should, therefore, be seen to make a contribution to a global database on these issues, which particularly lack data from less developed countries. The results from Belgrade confirm the existence of gender differences in travel behaviour and in the impact of transport demand management measures. They are compatible with those obtained from other parts of the world: men drive a car more often and cover longer distances, travelling primarily because of 'work' and 'business', unlike women whose travel purposes are most often related to household and family duties.

No gender differences in walking distance were identified. However, this result is related to the location where drivers managed to find a vacant parking space, and not to the acceptable walking distance. Further research is needed to examine whether there are differences in walking distance that men and women accept. This parameter is an important indicator in regard to sustainable behaviour.

It is interesting to note that in general men and women applied different parking search strategies. Men prefer to first arrive at the destination and then to start searching for parking, whereas women search in advance while approaching the destination.

Both genders ranked offered parking quality parameters in the same way. The quality parameters that were presented to respondents can be reconsidered: some new parameters can be added and/or some existing parameters can be excluded. For example, the parameter 'to be easy to perform the park/unpark manoeuvre' can be added. We investigated this parameter, but later excluded it because it was not significant to the 'average' user. However, maybe that is because the average user is a man. On the other hand, it can be expected that this parameter is more important to women. This assumption is supported by recent initiatives in some countries to mark special parking spaces for women that are larger in size than standard ones.

When analysing the results presented in this paper, it should be kept in mind that they are collected from a sample of drivers who parked in the central area. Because a restrictive parking regime is applied there, this sample clearly differs from the general population of drivers, especially in terms of the acceptance of transport demand management measures. In this regard, a minority share of women drivers who park in the central area compared to their share in total number of trips in the city tells us that women accepted implemented demand management measures more readily and changed their behaviour accordingly. This was confirmed once again by the question on a hypothetical parking price change, where women were shown to be more willing to give up parking in the zone and switch transport mode. Further research is needed to show the main reason why women adopt sustainable behaviour more than men: women's lower personal income and greater price sensitivity or (just as in Sweden [Polk 2003, 2004]) their greater environmental awareness?

Confirmation that there are significant gender differences suggests that gender should be an indispensable parameter when travel behaviour is examined and modelled. Further studies are needed to better understand which parameters impact travel decisions for both men and women. This understanding should contribute to the creation of transport policy that is equal to both genders.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the authors.

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